

The Waiting Room Interview

Written by

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LOGLINE: A routine interview preparation spirals into something far stranger when a man meets an unexpected companion in the waiting room.

DIRECTORS STATEMENT: This film explores the quiet psychological pressure we place on ourselves in moments of judgment - interviews, evaluations, first impressions. I wanted to capture the internal tension between who we are and who we think we're supposed to be.

The waiting room is intentionally minimal and liminal: a space where time feels suspended, where the mind wanders, where anxieties echo louder than reality. Mark represents the unexpected forces - internal or external - that challenge the masks we wear. Through stillness, silence, and subtle shifts in tone, the film invites the audience to question what is real, what is imagined, and what we reveal only when pushed.

Rather than offering clear answers, the film aims to create a psychological experience: a moment where the familiar becomes strange, and the simple act of waiting becomes a confrontation with the self.

INFLUENCES:

Severance (sterile liminality)

The Killing of a Sacred Deer (unsettling calm)

Black Mirror (psychological tension)

A24 minimalism

TICK. TOCK. GOES THE CLOCK.

FADE IN:

1

INT. WAITING ROOM

1

Liminal white walls. A clock reaches three.

ZOOM out to reveal a row of chairs lined. One is occupied by **JAKE** (30s), who sits on the edge, rehearsing under his breath, timid:

JAKE
(muttering)
Now, I understand this opportunity
you're offering me is extremely
important, and I'm committed to
contributing in any way I can...

He grimaces, pulling out a notepad. Reading from it:

JAKE (CONT'D)
(quietly)
...which is why I will dedicate
myself fully to the role.

His rehearsal is shortly ended when **MARK** (30s) enters. He saunders past the empty chairs and sits besides..

Jake, who becomes disturbed, glances - tense. A beat. He turns back to his papers. A long awkward moment passes before the next words are spoken-

MARK
First time?

JAKE
Me?

Mark glances around. The room is empty. Jake exhales, awkwardly laughs.

JAKE (CONT'D)
Sorry - yeah.

Mark notices the awkwardness. He offers up his name.

MARK
My name's Mark. How long have you
been waiting?

Jake checks the clock.

JAKE
It's three now...so exactly an
hour.

MARK

I'm here for the three o'clock.

He points to the open notepad, full of scribbled notes, then says:

MARK (CONT'D)

Y'know, I was just like you once.

(beat)

Spent too long rehearsing. Things tend to work out better when you leave a little unsaid.

Jake frowns.

JAKE

And how would I do that?

MARK

Start by removing the notes.

(off Jake)

Trust me. It works.

Jake hesitates, then places the notepad back into his bag.

MARK (CONT'D)

Now, are you fine with me asking you a few common questions? Practice answering them. It'll help.

Jake nods - approving of this idea.

MARK (CONT'D)

Okay great...firstly, how did you travel here?

JAKE

I took the 221 bus. This place isn't far from my house.

MARK

Was it difficult to find?

JAKE

(uneasy)

Not really. It's around the corner from the station. I suppose it might've been somewhat confusing for the first time.

MARK

Did you notice anyone else when you arrived?

JAKE

No, it seemed pretty quiet.

(beat)

I'm sorry, but are these really the questions they'll be asking?

MARK

Stay with me. You're doing well.

Just a couple more.

(beat)

Do you believe first impressions are permanent?

JAKE

I suppose they can be, depending on the situation.

MARK

Would this be one of those situations, Jake?

JAKE

I guess... I mean... I don't know... yes. Yes, it is.

MARK

Did you regret walking through that door?

JAKE

(freaked out)

I don't know. I've just been waiting so long.

(beat)

Look, Mark, I appreciate your help, but I think that's enough—

Before he can finish, Mark interrupts.

MARK

What is your biggest weakness?

Jake pauses. A normal question. Not what was expected.

JAKE

Hm...I would say...my weakness is--

MARK

Remove the fillers. Repeat from "My weakness is.."

Jake swallows. The clock becomes incessantly stronger. Quicker.

JAKE

My weakness is that I see myself as a perfectionist--

MARK

Repeat. None of that perfectionism nonsense.

JAKE

(bothered)

My weakness would be that I can be overly committed to my work, sometimes at the expense of-

MARK

They want the truth.

JAKE

I suppose I can be too focused on small details, which can slow me down at times.

MARK

Again.

JAKE

Sometimes I try too hard to make sure everyone is happy.

MARK

And Again!

The clock culminates to a loud, pressuring rhythm.

JAKE

I'm just trying to give the kind of answer they expect!

MARK

THEN DO IT PROPERLY, FOR GOD'S SAKE!

JAKE

(furious)

My weakness is that I'm afraid of being seen for who I really am!

An extended beat of tension release. The clock dies down, returning to normal.

MARK

(patting on the shoulder)

Good...that's good. Well done. That's it. You did good.

JAKE

You think so?

MARK

It's never about what I think.

(beat)

(MORE)

MARK (CONT'D)
Look, you've been waiting for a long time, I think you should go and knock on that door, tell 'em you're here.

He points to an ominous door. On it, a door sign: "Do Not Disturb"

JAKE
It says do not disturb.

MARK
I think they owe you an explanation for their lateness.

Jake takes a moment to reflect, then beelines for the door.

JAKE
Okay...I'm doing it.

He stares at the door. *It looks bigger from here, ominous.* He slowly presses his hand against the door handle and pushes.

JAKE (CONT'D)
Sorry to disturb-

FROM THE WAITING ROOM

He freezes.

JAKE
..scanning the room...

REVERSE ANGLE:

Empty.

INT. INTERVIEW ROOM

He explores the room.

An open blind welcomes a cold breeze.

Nothing but a chair and standing mirror set up facing opposite each other.

JAKE
(to MARK)
It's empty in here! Not a single soul.

Silence.

JAKE (CONT'D)

Mark?

Jake waits a beat for an appropriate response.

JAKE (CONT'D)

Mark.

He turns back around, returning to the other room.

INT. WAITING ROOM

...but Mark is gone.

On Jake's seat lies a note. He picks it up and reads:

MARK (V.O)

Congratulations on completing your
interview, Jake.

Realization dawns.

JAKE

I never told him my name.

Continuing:

MARK (V.O)

You passed. Are you proud of
yourself? Either way, you start
tomorrow. See you soon!

Jake looks around the empty room—proud, but still vulnerable.
The clock ticking ceases.

FADE OUT.